the floor, bed-sheets spread and all the cousins slept in one line, often waking up in a jumble of arms and legs. Dada also opened bank accounts for all of us in the Bank of Maharashtra on Karve Road, with a princely sum of Rs 5 each, being the minimum balance for a savings account. During the holidays, when visitors came over, they would either bring sweets or give us a couple of rupees as a gift. I would deposit this in my account and feel very grown-up whenever I got my passbook updated. We were thus introduced to the world of banks and the saving habit at an early age. Going to Peshwe Park, playing there on the swings, slides and see-saws, rounded up with 'bhel' was a cherished outing. So also going up the hill to Hanuman Tekdi (hillock) and racing each other down, stumbling and falling and grazing our knees and elbows. I remember that on one holiday we had gone to the hill in the morning. Some more cousins came over later in the day and I volunteered to guide them to the hill in the evening. By the time we came back, I was so exhausted that '*tondatna shabda suddha phutat nahwta*' (too tired to even utter a word) or even have dinner. I just slept and woke up only the next morning to the worried looks of my parents.

My mother's youngest sister, Nirmala, who for some reason we used to call rather informally Rita, had married Shridhar Krishna Kogekar, a civil engineer in the Military Engineering Services (MES). They had two daughters: Veena, who was my age, and Uma, who was six years younger. Because of the age difference between my brother Nitin and me and between Veena and Uma, more often than not Veena and I would end up playing together. Moreover, the others were mostly abroad, in Sweden and Canada. We would spend hours together, much to the exclusion of everything and everyone else. Both our parents being in the Central Government, they would sometimes be

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